Something to be said for moonshine

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35595553.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Catra & Huntara (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Huntara (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer was supposed to be in here more but then she passed out and her section got invaded, if you don't have canonical aliens homemade is fine

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Post-Season/Series 05, Post-Canon, Canon Compliant, IN SPACE!, Alcohol, drunkenness treated VERY lightly, battle couple catradora, i owe huntara an apology, utter blatant textual disrespect for the laws of science, Comedy with Feelings, that should really be a standard tag

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by ForsythiaRising

Summary

Huntara vs. the desert (vs. that awful catgirl), space edition.

Or: She's an intergalactic visitor. Unfortunately. This one time. Never again.

Or: Huntara has a drink or five with those kids who saved the universe.

Notes

Here is the Huntara fic no one asked for, paired with taking the idea that Etheria only has moonlight way too seriously, which is also something no one asked for. The world's most enormous THANK YOU to caminante, who has been the kindest person in the world over this (and over everything else, tbh, and this is THEMATIC in a way I can't quite articulate briefly here). Also worth noting that C does magnificent podfic work that I HIGHLY ENCOURAGE you, dear reader, to listen to. No really, go do that first. I'll wait.

Also thank you to the whole crowd who put up with me while I wrote this (wow, I sure do say that in author's notes a lot, huh), and especially the folks who inspired and joined me down the moon-themed rabbit hole. You know who you are. (...caminante again. Other folks too, but caminante again. Seriously, caminante, this is all your fault for talking about Adora and the sun.)

Please drink responsibly.

See the end of the work for more notes

Planet Hydrelium, Festival of Drink

"What the *fuck* is *that?"*

Huntara prides herself on taking things in stride. She does it in the Waste all the time - the Waste, with its quicksand and snakes and gang wars, where everything wants to kill you, and the way to stay alive is to be the best at killing it right back. She's used to surprises, and to taking advantage of them rather than standing around whining, which is why those words could not possibly have come from her own mouth.

Except: they did. She glares at the giant, violently bright golden orb in the sky, presumably making all this *heat*. Glaring at it hurts, which means she glares harder. She refuses to put up a hand for shade.

"Uh," Bow says, face covered in dark glasses as he looks up at her from the end of the gangplank, "uh, you're not supposed to look directly at it."

There's water pooling in Huntara eyes, which squint against the burn. No, not squint. They're *narrowing.* In a *challenge*.

She could do this forever. Absolutely. Really. No giant alien *orb* is going to get the better of her, not mere minutes after she's turned up on a planet that isn't Etheria for the first time. Not before she even exits the ship. And maybe she *would* do this forever, but something taps the back of her legs one too many times to be comfortable, and she refuses to allow herself to feel relief when she turns her glare on the much less painful form of her traveling companion.

"Excuse me," the little science alien man says, in his nasal, officious voice that makes her want to punch him in the throat, "I'm trying to get past."

Huntara does not move.

He waves two pale-fingered hands at her fruitlessly for a moment, during which time she eschews looking at him to instead briefly fantasize an alternate ending to yesterday's altercation, in which he had tried to examine her sword-staff and she had simply taken it away instead of letting it deploy in his face. Eventually, he pushes past her, arduously attempting to yank his overly large cart of nonsense objects past her unbudging legs. She doesn't look at him, but his pathetic little grunts suggest he's putting his back into it, which is probably good for him.

"Ugh!" He announces. His cart is still pressing against the back of her calf, so presumably he's giving up. He reaches past her to instead take each item out of the cart and stack it on the spaceship gangplank, one by one. He mutters and even chatters at Bow as he does, but Huntara pays none of it any mind.

Instead, Huntara takes a deep, full breath.

She's glad She-Ra saved Etheria. She's proud that their planet can lay claim to that kind of power and to magic, even if it's something she's still getting used to. She tries not to mind the Crimson Waste's new coating of sand-moss and the way the cacti seem always to be everywhere and in bloom, these days, with more flowers springing up every time she looks again. She tries not to curl her lip at it, not when it hasn't seemed to impact the local wildlife, somehow (ugh, more magic). Not when it was the trade for survival of the planet, not when survival is - has always been - Huntara's goal.

Still: it's been some time, since Huntara was last in a true desert.

The air is brighter and hotter than the Crimson Waste's has ever been, but it has an edge of harsh familiarity, and it smells pleasantly of booze. It is better by far than being trapped in a little alien spaceship with the most annoying little alien to ever swing by the newly-universed planet Etheria with a ride. Observing the landscape, she finds it primarily sand, which she likes, mostly flat with the occasional dune, though as she watches the horizon the air takes on a shimmery, undefined miasma that

Huntara doesn't like at all. She likes even less that the burning ball in the sky is accompanied - now that she takes stock - by four similar ones, each tinted a different color in their unreasonable brightness. Closer in, she sees the spaceship has landed beside a dozen or so large open-air tents, filled with this strange planet's gem-adorned, sand-colored denizens and bustling with celebratory chatter that nearly drowns out the desert's ambient noise.

Much more welcome, it is equally filled with a bevy of kegs and bottles and tankards, all free-flowing in what Huntara has been promised is the galaxy's foremost desert-based liquor festival, also known as the only thing that would get Huntara to leave Etheria or the Waste at all, thank you very much. Amid the aliens, she can make out Adora's blonde hair holding court at a particularly rambunctious table next to the Queen Glimmer's pink bob. As Huntara watches, the latter - also in dark glasses - points out the newly arrived spaceship, and Adora waves with loose, overenthusiastic frenzy before the pair make their way towards Huntara. Here in front of the ship, Bow waits patiently with a tankard in each hand.

"Done!" science man shouts. Huntara ignores him, and then - the sound of his inconsequential groan - steps forward onto the part of the gangplank that shines in the too-bright light of whatever fucking defective moons these are.

Immediately, she recoils back into the ship. "*What* the *fuck!"* She glares at the metal, which - it turns out - is hot enough to burn, even through her heavy boot.

"What?" comes a voice Huntara never wanted to hear again, "too harsh for you?"

The fluffy asshole with the tail and the bad fucking attitude saunters around the side of the ship, emerging from a blind spot with movements that are, while casual, so silent that they didn't even register on Huntara's sweep. Somehow, she's able to stand the heat on her bare feet, padding along the sand with her midriff bare and hair far shorter than it was the last time Huntara saw

her. Her own dark glasses perch cooly at the bridge of her nose and, as Huntara turns to her, she stretches her whole body languidly, arms and neck and torso stretching up and about like she revels in the light of the - ugh, whatever the fuck *this* is. Her eyes are scrunched and she exudes nothing but contentment, which Bow seems to be particularly delighted by. For Huntara's part, the whole display rings sour - all she can think of when she looks at Fluffy over here is mocking laughter and nasty triumph, the way she'd used Huntara's gang to pick off the three Etherian partygoers here today one by one, then loomed over the grounded cockpit of an abandoned spaceship and introduced herself not just Huntara's rival, but her conqueror.

Huntara twirls her sword-staff ominously, letting the blade *shiing!* out of its sheath as she holds it as an overt threat. "What is *she* doing here?" Huntara asks, and this time she doesn't think of it as whining at all. This is threat assessment.

The mocking laugh is just the same, and it sets Huntara's teeth on edge. It's even worse when Catra - because, yes Huntara knows her name, and knows it all too well - says disingenuously, "Didn't anyone tell you? I'm a *good guy* now."

Huntara had, indeed, heard something like that. Doesn't mean she'd believed it. Catra is *of the Horde*, as far as Huntara's concerned, in a way that few people are - ruthless and nasty and underhanded, and Huntara can't look at her without seeing the Valley of the Lost overrun with Horde soldiers.

Still: "Adora?" Huntara asks, without taking her eyes off Catra. Because Adora is here now, bouncing ungracefully up to them with Glimmer and one of the sand-colored - no, Huntara thinks as they get closer, *made of sand,* oh, that is *weird* - aliens in tow. As young as Adora may be, she's also She-Ra, and Huntara knows where to defer.

Except maybe she doesn't. Because, "Huh?" is all Adora says. She's staring at Catra like all her brains have been sucked out with a straw, and she sounds like an absolute idiot.

Catra looks even more smug, if anything. "They *like* me."

Huntara eyes her skeptically. "I thought Horde Prime was the one doing the brainwashing."

Catra's demeanor changes from one moment to the next, in the time it takes Huntara to blink. One second, she's preening in the light; the next, she's launching herself towards Huntara, face grotesque in a hissing snarl. Another, similar hiss comes from a place in the brightness by the spaceship, and Huntara is surprised to see a large, spiky-red catlike creature puffed up and hissing the same way Catra is. Huntara barely has time to take this new threat in before Catra lunges, and Huntara's ready for her. She's almost disappointed when Glimmer and Bow catch at Catra's arms, stopping her in her tracks. Catra turns to hiss at them, instead.

"Hey, *Adora*!" Bow says loudly, with false, blatantly-changing-the-subject cheer, "You should *tell Huntara* about *suns!"*

"Oh no," Glimmer says. Still wrangling Catra, she says a somewhat rueful, "here we go." In a contrast to her tone, she flashes Huntara a somewhat gleeful *let me show you something fun* smile. Catra turns her glare on Glimmer, and while she doesn't say the word *traitor,* it's in her gaze.

Which is funny, all things considered.

"The *sun!*" Adora announces imperiously, wobbling a bit as she does. She is practically shouting, certainly louder than reasonable necessity, "is a *perfectly normal*, naturally occurring, in *no way* problematic—"

"Adora has *history* with the sun," Bow explains.

"—everyday, totally basic thing that is on *most planets*, and you should absolutely *not* be alarmed by how it seems like it *should* be a moon but is *on fire,* or how—"

"She thought it was attacking the planet," Glimmer says.

"She tried to punch it," Bow says.

"—big it is or how bright it is, or that it can burn your *skin*. That's all very normal, too! There are these screens for it and everything, which people use *all the time…*"

"...is Blondie drunk?"

"Drunk?" Bow sounds incredulous, "She's coherent *and* on topic. Not even close."

Glimmer snorts. "Give her twenty minutes," she says, "And then you'll see *drunk*."

—

Huntara gives her twenty minutes. Huntara doesn't really have a choice, because there's a *cream* and she has to put it on her *feet.*

("And everywhere else," science man had said obnoxiously, "to protect you from the suns. Really, if you'd only listened to me *two days ago*—"

"I stopped listening to you," Huntara had grunted, propping her other leg against the spaceship's console so she could rub cream into her thigh, "ten minutes after we left Etheria."

Science man had spluttered, staring at her with that peachy-orange she's come to interpret as a blush. Bow and Glimmer had sported similar expressions, and she'd ignored them too, though she'd derived a certain smugness from the quiet exchange they engaged in, which amounted to *sure wish Adora was here* from one, followed by *sure glad Catra isn't* from the other.)

"WHO AM Iiiii*iii*!?!!?!" Adora is wailing in overwrought tones, standing on a table with someone's white cloak wrapped

haphazardly around her and two bright green bottles held up in front of her eyes, "IF NOT AN EX*AL*TED - uhhh, something, uhhh *whatever* - AN EXALTED SOMETHING OF HOoOOoOORDE PRI— *ooh!*" she tips her head under one of the bottles held next to her eye, "Is that a *fish?!*" she bobs her head, trying to make it follow what Huntara suspects was merely a glint of the light.

The crowd of alien onlookers she seems to have accumulated laughs. One of them calls, "Poor - what was his name, again?" and that launches Adora into another grandiose, disjointed...something. Huntara leaves her to it, and tries again to accustom herself to the desert. This time, the extra heat is - not pleasant, exactly, but certainly bearable. And while she does not *like* the idea of her vision obstructed in any way, she can't deny that the glasses make things...better.

"*Ten suns!?"* science man is saying behind her, another interruption to her reverie. His voice is increasingly hysterical as he questions the sandy planetary native, "How do you survive with *ten suns!?"*

Sandy shrugs, smiling. "No no no, that one's *called* the Tentasun. When it's up we know it's time for the Festival of Drink. Not that we've had one in ages - Horde Prime wasn't really into that kind of thing." A shiver runs through Huntara. She understands Horde Prime both too well and not at all, exposed as she was at length to an organization inspired by him and then briefly to his hive mind. Sandy rallies from the sudden gloom of her words, chirping out, "*Anyway* - lore has it they used to use this time to dump out half the liquor we've made and drink the other half. But in celebration of Horde Prime's defeat, we're just drinking it *all* this time - to make up for the time we've lost!" She holds her mug up in a toast, knocks back a gulp, then pauses, eyes furrowed as she remembers the thread of conversation. "We actually have twelve suns. What, how many does your planet have?"

Science Man splutters. "Just *one!"* He declares in a high pitched screech.

Next to him, though, Bow is fully engaged. He says thoughtfully, "We don't have *any*. Or, well, we didn't, anyway. Do we have suns now?"

Huntara grunts. Glimmer says, "I...don't know?"

"I mean, maybe." Ugh, Catra is back. She's glaring at Huntara, and Huntara glares back. "Suns are just stars, right? We have those now."

"Entrapta would know," Glimmer says.

"...though you think we'd notice something like that…" Bow mutters.

"Speaking of Entrapta," Catra says acerbically, "Couldn't we get *her* to do this?"

"She was busy," Bow replies, "And anyway, all we need is someone to figure out why they're struggling to grow crops. Jeff is...fine."

"How," Science Man is tugging on his hair, "could that *possibly be?!* Suns are *huge!* And between the gravitational pull of *each one* and the solar flares—"

"Oh," Sandy says cheerfully, "we don't worry about that!"

Science Man lets out a bit of a scream.

"He's drilling into the *planet,* Bow*,"* Catra is saying, sharp and annoyed. And indeed, that's what Science Man is doing, there in the midst of all the tents.

"That's how you take readings, Catra," Bow volleys back placidly.

Huntara doesn't like it.

"I don't like it," Catra replies grumpily, like a fucking dumbass.

"Ah!" Briefly, Huntara's attention is drawn to Adora, who has stumbled into a sitting position on the table in the tent. The people watching her are laughing again, and Huntara eyes them until it's clear that the laughter is good-natured - not that Huntara cares; Blondie can take care of herself, Huntara knows that well enough. Even if Adora *is* off her ass drunk. And trying to…put her foot? on her head? That does seem to be the goal. She has two stained, triangular napkins placed on her head, presumably set to stick point-upwards except for how one tumbles town onto the table as she shouts about "It was just like— nope— *almost got it* —"

"Wait," Huntara says, the words she'd barely bothered listening to clicking into place, "What do you mean, crops? This is a desert."

Glimmer starts, "*Well*—" Then she stops, looks perplexed. "— Bow?"

Bow shrugs. "Apparently, they did. Standard desert fare aside, story goes the land used to irrigate *itself* for a season - this was actually the festival they'd have to start the planting season, though it's been barren here all year round all the time since Horde Prime came. They've been relying on imports, and no one's from before him is alive to remember...any of the details, really." He sighs. "We've tried to run the water in artificially, but both the native water and the stuff we've brought in just makes the surface level gross for a bit and then evaporates right up. Not even Perfuma could help."

"And *then,"* Science Man wails, on his knees in front of his devices, which he shoves deeper into the ground like that will do him any good, "how would the orbits *even work—"*

"There, there, Jeff," Bow says placatingly, "just take your readings."

"But it makes no *sense,* this place shouldn't *exist—"*

"Ooh, *Huntara's* back!" Adora's voice is overloud, shouting across from her spot now standing on the table again (this time in a dramatically contorted position with arms outstretched and one leg up, like she'd frozen in place while running and was trying - and failing - not to move). She falls out of her pose, and her expression gets bright enough to rival the sun just as the face of the fluffy asshole leaning against the table beside her - when did she get over there? *Dammit*, how does she *do that?* - goes equally dark. "Huntara! Ooh, ooh! A - a *toast!"*

Adora bends all the way forward in half at the waist, hair flopping down in front of her before her whole body whips back up into standing, a tankard in one hand triumphantly like a prize. She stumbles two steps, steadies, holds the tankard high in the air, then bends her head back as far as it will go to look up at it.

Huntara raises an eyebrow as Adora loses her coordination yet again in the act, pitching sideways and sloshing booze such that it drips onto her own forehead, staying upright only by the guiding hand Catra braces on her legs from below. She giggles like she barely noticed the whole thing, shaking the liquid off her face in a motion like a wet dog and then holding the tankard so close to her face that she goes cross eyed examining it.

"Toast," she says, halfway between matter of fact and perplexed. "Not toast." She looks quizzically down, once again losing track of her tankard so it sloshes sideways, almost dangling from her hand. She asks plaintively, "Ca*traaaaaaa*, do you have any *toooast*?"

As she trips her way stallingly off the table and into the crowd, Huntara asks Bow, "Hey, can't Blondie just...do her magic plant thing? It worked on Etheria. Made the Waste all…" a word comes to mind, but it makes bile rise in her throat to think, so long has she taken *pride* in the way the Waste could never be *that*, "...pretty." She can't keep a mild disgust out of her voice, and does not try.

"Nah, tried that. She did a lot of glowing and waving the sword around, like three different times; absolutely nothing. Went looking for one of those magic-controlling devices, too—"

"Found one!" Adora bounces bright and gentle like one of Etheria's daytime moons over to where Huntara is standing. Catra trails her like a thundercloud.

"A toast!" Adora announces proudly, holding out something that appears to be flat, bready, and singed. "Silica gave it to me!" She gestures wildly to the crowd, and a sand-woman covered half over in glittering crystals at the edge of it waves sheepishly. Huntara pinches the thing skeptically between her fingers, and Adora holds out her tankard in clear invitation.

"Uh…" Huntara says, eyeing it. She's about to tap Adora's mug with her…toast…when she finds it tugged out of her hand, a mug pushed into its place.

Bow takes a bite from the bread. "Not bad," he says.

"Uh-huh," Huntara says, then taps her newly acquired tankard to Adora's, knocking hers back just as a still-delighted Adora does the same, more or less.

It's not bad. Bow just said that, so she's not going to, but - it isn't. Hoppy but also a little sharp and a bit limey. Tart.

"Great. Perfect. Wonderful, *done*," Catra says caustically. She plucks the tankard out of Adora's hand, holding it at arms length when Adora first grabs at it and then pouts at her own failure. "You got your toast; now can we *go?"* Her eyes cut to Huntara, and it's very clear exactly what has her so brusque.

If it were anyone else, Huntara would leave them alone to hash this one out.

It isn't anyone else.

"Wouldn't be polite to leave a guest," Huntara drawls, as if she's ever given a rat's ass for polite.

"Huntar*aaaaa,"* Adora says, turning her attention back to her. Huntara would swear she can *hear* Catra's teeth grinding.

"*Adora,"* Catra grits out.

"*Hey, Catra*," Adora says in a voice that sounds like it might have briefly considered being a whisper in another life, "*did you see Huntara's* arms?"

"They're arms," Catra snarls, glaring at Huntara.

Adora's not really Huntara's type - too young, first and foremost, not to mention too small, and while she respects the girl enough for the attention to be flattering, she's not particularly inclined to encourage it. But Huntara's been thinking for a long time about what comeuppance she'd like to inflict on this asshole who'd dared to take the Waste and shake its confidence in Huntara's supremacy, only to defect to She-Ra's team thoroughly enough to cut Huntara's plans off at the knees. Which means Huntara can't punch her, and can't feed her to a Waste snake, so instead she pretends not to hear them (or Glimmer's groaning *"I need a drink"*) and casually shrugs off her vest, using it to wipe sweat from her brow.

(The light - sun - sears beats down on the now exposed parts of her back, which she realizes she never put the weird cream onto because it was covered. She grits her teeth and does not flinch.)

It has the desired effect.

For a moment.

"Ooh!! *Huntara,"* Adora says, flopping in a way that seems like she's going to fall directly into Huntara but then being pulled back by Catra's arm around her waist. She leans back into Catra easily, and does not seem to notice that her girl - because Catra *is* Adora's girl, the stories had said that, and while Huntara hadn't

entirely believed them then, her eyes tell her now that they were correct - is glaring at Huntara, ears pressed back and tail bottle-brush. "*Huntara* - did you *know* that Catra*aaa*—" she pats around behind her one-handed without looking, all but smacks Catra in the chest and then the face before Catra grabs her hand, "—*Catra* can *rip through metal* with her—"

She cuts off abruptly, head tilted onto Catra's shoulder as Catra - smirking a little, the absolute fucker - murmurs something Huntara can't hear in Adora's ear. Huntara has a flash of a memory - Adora's sword snatched by Catra's whip, Catra's goons with their hands on Adora's wrists, two tranquilizer darts in Huntara's own flesh while Adora shouts *get them out of here* and Huntara rushes to follow the order before she, too, can fade, leaving Adora bound and defiant and glaring at a triumphant Catra. And then she's back in the here and now as Adora's expression changes, from drunken enthusiasm to drunken awe, and Huntara feels her own eyebrows lift high on her forehead as Adora gives a clearly involuntary squeak, followed by an unimaginably high-pitched, "*Now!?"*

Catra's smirk turns to Huntara, like Huntara has any stake in this whatsoever. Huntara just snorts, disconcerted but only willing to take this nonsense so far.

Anyway, Adora is already ahead of herself, declaring loudly, "I*iiii'm* gonna leave….*Glimmer!*…in charge!"

Bow sighs (he's actually been doing that a lot, through their conversation, between volleys of conversation with Science Man - Huntara's just been ignoring him). He says, "Adora, you don't have to—"

"Y'hear that!" Adora throws her arm around a passing alien, who luckily looks more charmed than bothered, "This - *this* - THIS! This is Glimmer." She gestures to Glimmer, "She's in charge! While I am gone."

"*Adora,"* Catra says again.

Something in her voice makes Adora perk up, grabbing her hand to tug her away, moving off into the dunes with a "Sosorrygottagobyeseeyoualllate*rrrrrrrrr*!" thrown drunkenly over her shoulder.

After a moment of watching them disappear amidst the sand and docked spaceships, Huntara asks, "Is Blondie—"

"She'll be fine," Glimmer says. Huntara...will admit to more concern than she'd like, with Adora in that state, with Catra being who she is - but there's not much she can do here, she figures, not without Glimmer and Bow backing her, not on this one. And anyway, the next thing Glimmer says is, "Hey - there's a local over there who swears he can drink absolutely anyone under the table in ten minutes or less."

"Ha!" Huntara says, and commits to herself to keep an eye out for Adora, but lets herself be pulled away. She's loath to admit it, but the shade of the tent feels good on the bare skin of her back. "We'll see about *that."*

Planet Hydrelium, Festival of Drink (still)

Queen Glimmer makes it two drinks before she hits the floor.

In Huntara's defense (not that she needs one), she thought the contest was all in good fun. Good, particularly competitive fun, but good fun. Sure, Glimmer *seemed* like she'd be a lightweight who bit off more than she could possibly chew when challenging Huntara to a drinking contest, but then she and her friends had never *seemed* like they were going to bring forth the mystical power of She-Ra and save Etheria and also the universe the first time they'd traipsed in to Huntara's favorite bar. Huntara had stopped underestimating this crowd, back then, and she'd decided not to start again today.

She probably should have started again today.

"What do we *do?"* Sandy is asking the question of Huntara, of all people.

Huntara is somewhat distracted by the giant mass that has arisen from the earth - really, really giant, bigger than the tents, bigger maybe than anything they have in the Waste. Anything they have *still alive* in the Waste, anyway. The mass is long and thick and as it rises sand sloughs off it is cascading waves. The sound of it falling sifts through Huntara's sensitive ears even as she filters out the shouts and scramble of people around her, and she's so busy assessing the situation she barely has space to grind out a grunting, "Why are you asking *me?"*

"Well, *she* was in charge!" the woman points at Bright Moon's queen, slumped on the floor in Bow's lap.

Huntara is not convinced that that authority was valid or how it transfers, but she does know that any group of people has a habit of falling into line if you make it sound like they should.

"You," she says sharply, command falling easily into her voice. The woman stands a bit straighter, whether she knows it or not. "Get people out of the area. *Stand back,"* she calls this one louder, more to jolt anyone paralyzed into movement than anything, "I don't care what's in your tent, *leave it* - and *get out of the way."*

"Yikes," Bow is looking frantically between the arising sand beast and the passed out queen of Bright Moon. "Uh. I'll be with you. In a sec—"

"Don't sweat it, kid," Huntara tells him, eyes locked on her giant, newfound prey, "Get her to safety." Then, with just as much strength though less projection of her voice, she says resolutely, "*This thing's* gonna have to deal with *Huntara."*

On the final word, she leaps.

The next few minutes are a series of hits and stabs, ducks and dodges; hard presses of offense when possible and brief stints of defense when necessary. Decisions made by body and reflex and training, physical sequences she understands how to adapt through better than any conversation she's ever had.

It's been a while, she realizes, in a brief, unwelcome thought between dodging one giant, sand-shifting tentacle and stabbing her sword-staff as deep as she can into the rubbery flesh of another. She doesn't like it when she thinks during times like this, prefers to go by *feel.* But it has indeed been a while, since anything in the Waste was as dangerous as this.

It's not fun - this has never been *fun,* she's never been the kind to enjoy it - but it is, in its way, grimly satisfying.

Until it's not.

There were too many tentacles, she'll think later. Too many of them, and they were too damn big, each and every one as wide as she is tall twice over. Too many of them, and too big, and Huntara was out of practice. She'll even admit, maybe, privately, with a chip to her pride that stings like every knock she's taken twofold, that this desert had already proved multiple times over to be more dangerous than the Crimson Waste ever was.

Later, she'll think all this. But it happens so fast, now. Before she even realizes the problem, it's already too late.

She's got her foot braced on one gargantuan tentacle as her sword-staff drives into another, and suddenly three more are upon her from every direction, large and flailing and combined with waves of buffeting sand. She tries to hang on, but first her feet on the ground and then her grip on her sword rip away, and then - sand; blunt force to her shoulder. A loud *crack* and sharp pain at her knee. Head and leg and hip against wood, a shower and mouthful of liquor as something splinters; a mouthful of sand and a faceful of sand and sand, sand, *sand,* her whole body pressed into it and she cannot *breathe* and for fuck's *sake* she is *Huntara*

of the Crimson Waste, she is formidable and strong, she is harsh as the desert she chose a life in, she is her rivals' nightmare made flesh and this is a really fucking *stupid* fucking way for her to die, face-first in alien sands covered in booze and giant-tentacle and mother*fucking* sunlight.

She'd like to say that's all she needed, that affirmation to herself. She'd like to say that let her find the power she needed to prevail.

It doesn't.

What does happen is, faintly, in a voice so muffled through the sand that Huntara can barely hear it, someone shouts something about honor.

Huntara doesn't notice that. She's busy being crushed to death—

—and then she isn't.

The pressure lets up all at once, a rush of wind and sand whipping past along with it. Huntara fucking *gasps* the air in, then coughs up sand, then gasps again.

She flips blearily onto her back, and the brightness is fucking *mind-searing*. Her eyes slam shut, but even then the brightness pounds through her eyelids; painfully, she raises a hand to feel at her face. Shards of darkened glass crumble in her fist, the sunglasses utterly shattered.

"Hey loser," that fucking *voice* drawls from somewhere above her, and she *hates* it. She kind of hopes she's dead just so she can know they both are. But no, Catra continues, "Someone need some help down there?"

Something hard but small falls directly onto her face. It hits her nose, which she realizes now is broken. A lesser woman would shout; Huntara remains silent.

A greater woman, however, might be able to refuse the condescending gift. Huntara cannot, and she uses her good hand - the other one, she realizes, is not doing so great, what with the shooting pain and awkward angle and all - to stuff the glasses on her face. There is a smear on one lens that is almost certainly blood from her nose, but otherwise it - helps.

It means Huntara can look up to see Catra, standing sun-touched and cool, one hand on her hip while the other adjusts her own sunglasses. She stands there just long enough to confirm that Huntara can see her smirk - fucking *bitch* - before leaping atop one of the tentacles with claws outstretched. Huntara can see her digging in with their sharp tips and flinging her legs astride the thing like she's aiming to ride it. The tentacle flails and Catra snarls, digging in harder, and then Huntara has to use strength she isn't sure she has left to *roll over* before it comes down in her *head,* fluffy asshole passenger and all.

Huntara tries to use that same strength to stand, which is how she learns that one of her legs is out too. Fuck*dammit* all.

Instead, she's able to claw her way up a nearby keg, tugging herself upwards under she can prop her back against it. It's not a place where she can *do* much, but it's better than lying on the ground, and it gives her a better view of the fight, so she can try to track the movements of—

Oh.

Huntara is still wearing sunglasses. She has to check, though, to confirm, because suddenly everything is bright, bright, *bright*.

And Huntara has *seen* She-Ra before, is the thing. Has kneeled in awe of her in the sand, bathed in a glow that she knows now is as bright as a sun but as gentle as Etheria's moonlight on the eyes. Huntara wishes she could take off these glasses, just to see it unfettered.

Huntara has seen She-Ra before. But she has never seen She-Ra like *this.*

She's tall, but She-Ra was always tall. Glowing, but She-Ra was always that too. Dressed in white and gold and absolutely *formidable*-looking, which...okay, none of those things are new, though the way this updated configuration sits across her even-broader shoulders *feels* new. Her hair is gold and lush as it ever way, but this time it's high on her head in a ponytail.

If Huntara were less awestruck, she'd laugh when she sees the poof.

As it is, she's almost too dumbfounded to react to anything with more than a stare, even the tentacle she sees coming but - crucially - She-Ra *doesn't*. She-Ra is fully engaged with a large group of them that are writhing in midair - using...magic rainbow energy? From her *sword!?* - and it's one of the thinner ones, separate from the rest, almost sharp in its whip-like motion towards She-Ra's unprotected back. Huntara tries to shout a warning, but it comes out as a hoarse, pathetic thing, and fuck, *fuck*—

"Gotcha," Fluffy calls, leaping from one tentacle to another to the one aimed at She-Ra. She flings herself towards it, digging in with both sets of claws so her whole body dangles downwards from the tentacle. It bends backwards with her weight, away from where She-Ra slices her sword forward without even turning around to check the scene behind her.

At least not visually. She-Ra is practically surfing on one of the midair tentacles when she calls, "Okay over there?"

"Peachy," Fluffy grunts out, still dangling. Then, conversational and a bit acerbic, strained but barely, "Could use a lift, though, when you get a sec."

Despite her ostensible relaxation, Huntara can see even from the ground the tremble in her arms as she tries to hang on to the

tentacle above her. The tentacle whips from side to side, and Catra whips with it, holding on until she can't anymore.

Before that happens, a sound filters into the pounding in Huntara's head. It's a screaming-trilling-beeping, mechanical and loud, and Huntara spends a moment groaning at the pound of it against her skull before she manages to place it. She reaches out with her good leg, uses it to *kick* little Scientist Man's strange device over in the sand, yanking its sensor out of the ground so it'll stop that infernal *beeping*. Which is *stupid,* because the ground isn't even *wet* here; in fact, it's bizarrely dry despite the multiple overturned kegs that surround it. Which is actually—

There's a shout, loud and abrupt.

Huntara turns.

Catra is falling - no, *plummeting*. It would be almost hard to see her, if Huntara's ears were not so well attuned to making sound into location, because she seems to have lost her grip high, high in the air, higher than any of the other tentacles have gone, and it's not entirely clear if the plummet will take her into a crumple on the ground or directly into a squirming, central mass of tentacles, no doubt clustered to hide a gaping maw.

Huntara grunts, gritting her teeth against the pain that shoots through her when she tries once again to shift, though it's not like she knows what she could do about this anyway.

Not that it turns out she'd have to, once again. Because She-Ra is sliding past on another stream of rainbow light, and as she does she plucks Catra out of the sky, yanking her close for just a moment - they grin at each other, and Huntara can't make out more of their expressions, but can see She-Ra reach out to adjust Catra's sunglasses - before all but *tossing* her away, in the direction of another flailing mass of tentacles. This time, Catra springs through the air with both control and leverage, and it's not long before she's swinging herself into the melee once more.

"Took you long enough!" Catra calls once she's there, grinning ferally as she renews her clawed offense.

She-Ra flashes a smile, calling back a disingenuous, "Aww, were you *worried*?" while she drives her sword into a set of tentacles that look…are they smaller?

They're not, Huntara realizes, maybe a moment before the two women fighting seem to, as well. They're not smaller, they're *receding*, and indeed it isn't long before, with a final flail, the once gargantuan limbs have returned into the sand, leaving behind nothing but a strange calm of wind and sand and overturned tents, the husks of upended kegs and a scream of pain in Huntara's limbs and the distant, stressed chatter of dozens of former partiers, paused behind a defensive line made up of Bow and the strange cat-alien they call Melog and the barely coherent form of a plastered Queen Glimmer. As Huntara watches, Catra moves to join them, brushing her fur off without even glancing Huntara's way for a taunt. It pisses Huntara the fuck off how much that feels like a dismissal.

"Need a hand?"

Huntara turns her attention to the space in front of her, looking up to find She-Ra standing there with one outstretched. Huntara is once again dizzied a little to find how bright she is, even from behind sunglasses, and even moreso with multiple suns behind and above her. It puts once again into stark relief how much gentler the light on Etheria is - on Etheria, She-Ra is magnificent, brighter than anything else in the sky; here, it's like there's a competition for the brightest thing in Huntara's vision, and even behind glasses just the *concept* of how much intense light is standing before her makes Huntara's head hurt.

Alternatively, that might be a concussion. God*damn*, but everything hurts.

She uses her good hand to clasp She-Ra's, then uses the support to try to draw herself to standing, avoiding weight on her leg. As

she does, she watches gold light slide up from She-Ra's hand and onto Huntara's own arm, the light spreading like a balm. And then it recedes like the tentacle beast, curling its way back into She-Ra's skin, and Huntara...

...Huntara still feels like shit.

"Huh," She-Ra says, looking perplexed. The whole thing happens a second time, with the same result, to which She-Ra says a more emphatic, "*Huh."*

"You okay?" Huntara manages to grind out, leaning her weight on the solidity of She-Ra. *Too young*, she reminds herself, though *too small*, does not, at this time, apply. She uses the thought to stave off a quick moment of pain- and magic-induced insanity, and then adds a reminder that that's *Adora* in there, under all of She-Ra's...everything. She'd defy anyone not to have a moment of mental weakness at least against all...that. Or she would, if she ever planned to mention it, which she very firmly *does not.*

"I don't think this planet likes me very much," She-Ra says, partway between frustrated and annoyed and just confused, "I can't do a thing about the crops, and now it won't let me heal you, and...*ugh.* It's letting me do magic on myself, and that's about it."

Huntara grunts an acknowledgement. "No big, blondie," she says, though when she pays attention to it it does *feel* pretty big. Damn, that thing did a number on her. She hates to admit it, but it's a good thing She-Ra - and, sure, fine, the other one - were around to pick up her slack, especially when— "Wait, weren't you drunk?"

She-Ra laughs, "Oh, yeah, have been like five times today," Huntara tries to square that information. She-Ra must see the question on her face, because she phases back into Adora in a flash of light before adding cheerfully, "She-Ra sobers me right up! Could probably go again, even, though I think the party's pretty definitely over."

"Not to mention, no more booze," Catra approaches them again, walking more briskly than she probably has to and sliding that proprietary arm around Adora's waist when she arrives.

Huntara rolls her eyes. *Too young* and *too small* are back in full, and she hurts too much to bother giving Fluffy a hard time right now.

"What do you mean?" Adora asks.

Catra sweeps her free arm across the wreckage. "I just talked to - well, Bow talked to - pretty much everyone. It's all spilled and gone, even the individual bottles and glasses and shit. That thing had it out for the festival, that's for sure."

Huntara stares hard at the ground under her feet, listening to the words. Her head swims, but also - it's dry, she notices again. Sure, it's the desert, but there were a *lot of drinks* here, and now it's all...dry. She glares at Science Man's overturned device, trying to make sense of something that won't quite connect in her pain-filled brain. Huntara is not typically given to self-hatred, but her lack of clearheadedness in this moment frustrates her more than it usually would. She does her best to tell herself that that doesn't have to do with the company.

"...get you home," Adora is saying, and when Huntara manages to shift her gaze - *ouch, fuck, that hurts*, she does not wince - Adora is looking at her critically. The tone hits Huntara right in the pride, and she's about to grunt a flippant response when Catra talks over her, which she hates. She hates even more how she misses the start of the sentence due to the pounding in her head.

"...the thing? With the tentacles?"

"It's not coming back after all that," Adore replies. A hazy part of Huntara asks *why was it here at all?*, because it wasn't *normal* for a creature to be so bold, unless…she loses the thought, as Adora says, "I wanna try to heal Huntara on Etheria."

"Ugh, just because Loser over here can't hack it—"

"*Catra!"*

Anger shoots through Huntara in time with the genuine anger in Adora's voice, and then doubles when she realizes that she's being *defended*. She bares her teeth, but can't string together words quite fast enough before Adora is speaking again.

"Jeff can hang out and do his science. The rest can wait for the next supply run. We'll all come back and sort it out," she says.

We'll all bites through Huntara's aching head, a point of pride and a threat all at once. *Later*, she tells it, and lets She-Ra help her limp to the ship.

Salineas, The Famished Fish

Later, she decides the answer is *no.*

"But *why,"* Bow whines, from the other side of the far too fancy table, flopping forward onto it in a way that nearly upends his drink.

Far too fancy is a relative item. This isn't one of the fanciest places in Salineas, Bow assured her, but there's a real tablecloth and the staff keeps glancing nervously at the increasingly drunk young man she's sitting with, though it's a toss up whether it's his fame or Huntara's bulk that keeps anyone from outright commenting. What it's *not* is her bar back in the Waste, and that makes it far too fancy for her blood. The fact that *everywhere* is fancier than her bar in the Waste is not, as far as she's concerned, relevant.

Not that the Waste is so much better, these days. In a way, the whole planet is feeling too fancy her blood, its light too kind after

her return from the harsh conditions of Hydrelium. She tries not to think about that too hard.

"I'm needed here," she tells him shortly, because it's true enough. There are always things they need her for in the Waste. Maybe not the old stuff - fighting first the Waste itself and then the Horde for its rule, keeping everyone in line with her bulk and her threats and her rules - but...other stuff. A few of her old goons could use help taking over Grox's shop. Grenadine needs a taste tester for new drinks. Sometimes a fight even breaks out for her to break up, and Huntara might not be much of one for talking, but Perfuma's been on about some kind of *mediation training* when she visits, so—

"Pfffffft," he makes a long, skeptical noise. "They could spare you for a *party*; they c'n spare you for *this."*

This is the follow-up mission to Hydrelium, and Huntara doesn't see the point. She didn't like the place, and she hasn't liked the feeling she's had about it now that she's back from the place, and She-Ra had it handled. Huntara doesn't need to go, and she's pretty sure that's not why this kid is here anyway. Not when he's this maudlin about it.

Not that that should matter, because for all Flower Girl's suggestions, Huntara is no mediator, and she is *certainly* not a therapist. Does Huntara look like a therapist? Because if Huntara looks like a therapist - except no, she doesn't, because she's Huntara.

"Alright," she says anyway, "what's all this really about?"

Bow - who usually runs around with the absolute brightest smile, who sparkles probably more annoyingly than Bright Moon's queen even if he's less literal about it - slumps down against the table and stares morosely at his full shot glass. He looks at it like it's betrayed everything he holds dear and then kicked his puppy - do these kids have a puppy? Probably not, and that cat alien thing can take care of itself. And Adora and stupid fucking Catra can

take care of *them*selves, and Queen Glimmer has her flashy teleporting thing, so she guesses *he's* the puppy, which means he looks like someone kicked *him*, which Huntara has not done.

Huntara doesn't have a lot of patience for this kind of thing. But these are still the kids who liberated her mind from Horde Prime and saved the universe, which is why she's willing to trek out to this restaurant all the way in Salineas at his request, even if she won't go so far as returning off-planet at the same. And it's why she asks him, once again, "Well? Spit it out."

He looks at her with no change in his morose demeanor, then glares again at the glass. He reaches out to grab it and, though both he and the shot glass are stationary, misses. He looks at his empty grip with slow, confused betrayal, then tries again.

Huntara snatches it casually out of the way before he can reach it, though with his trajectory she's not quite sure he was going to manage it this time, either. In one smooth motion she downs it herself, then slams the glass back down in front of him.

"...you're ruining my love life," he says, which...what is she supposed to do with *that.*

What she does is grab the half-empty bottle on the table between them. She continues eyeing him skeptically as she takes a swig - skips the glass, this is not a *glass* sort of moment - and once she's swallowed says brusquely, "Look, kid, I'm flattered, but—"

"Not like *that,"* the kid says, rolling his eyes far more ostentatiously than she's ever seen him do sober. "Tha's for *Glimmer.* Who I! Am here for! *Glimmer.* Glimmer 'n *Adora."*

"What about 'em?"

"They think you're..." he hiccups a little. If she were someone else, she might call it adorable, "...really cool."

She's not sure what to do with that, either. Turns out she doesn't have to decide, because Bow keeps going. Not, however, before

making another grab for the shotglass. He misses again, so Huntara picks it up for him. He stares in confusion at his empty fingers once again, this time locked in a circle around air. Huntara sighs, moving to grab a bottle of water - one of those glass, fancy ones, and maybe this place is fancier than she thought. She pours a shot's worth into the small glass, which she then places directly into his hand.

He blinks once, then again, then lights up so happily Huntara really does feel like she almost sees sparkles around his face. He does not question why he was holding nothing one moment and a full shotglass the next; just knocks it back, slamming it back down on the table with an exaggerated *ah!*

Huntara fills it right back up.

"*Really* cool," he repeats. As quickly as his joy had come, it fades, and he makes another swipe for his glass - Huntara shifts it a few inches as he does, so he grabs it on the first try, "Glimmer doesn't think you're hot, though. Adora thinks you're hot." He pauses, the shotglass almost to his mouth, then stops, looking a bit horrified. He gesticulates broadly with the glass, and Huntara watches water fly out in a spray onto a nearby couple as he says, "Tha's not mine to share. But you already know, though. Right? Everyone knows. Adora thinks you're hot." He pulls his glass to his lips, then holds it away from his face, glaring with affront at its emptiness. At the table next to them, one member of the now wet couple begins to stand up, anger in her eyes. Huntara looks at her, and she sits back down. Huntara refills the kid's glass. "Glimmer doesn't," he says as she does, "but she does think *Catra's* hot. Adora thinks Catra's hot, too. I d'know who Catra thinks is hot. Except Adora. She definitely thinks Adora is hot. And maybe Scorpia, but don't tell Adora I said that. Or Perfuma, who also thinks you're hot." He knocks the shot glass back, then wipes his mouth with his sleeve. His eyebrows draw together, squinting like he's in pain. "I think I need a chart."

"...Uh-huh," Huntara says. She refills his glass once more, then shifts in her chair, leaning back into a lounge and cocking her

head. "...you got a point?"

"Yeah, like, twelve," Bow replies blankly, waving a hand towards his quiver, which is propped beside his chair. Then he amends, "Thirteen, actually, if you count the wonky one."

Huntara sighs.

She waits.

At length, Bow goes, "O*hhhhhh.* A *point."*

"Yes," Huntara says.

"The *point,"* he gets out, "'s that they think you're *cool*. All of them - Glimmer and Adora and Catra."

Normally Huntara wouldn't think twice at that, so she surprises herself by saying candidly, "I find that hard to believe."

Bow makes that perplexed face, sipping at the shotglass, and says, "Well, okay, maybe not Catra. You were *really easy* to take down that one time in the Waste." Huntara grimaces. "Actually, *we* didn't have that hard a time, either, after we got out of that pit. But we have Adora, so that doesn't really count." Huntara carefully keeps her face blank, this time. She wonders how long she need endure this, and fills up his glass again. "S'anyway. Glimmer. She thinks you're cool. And she's all afraid that you don' repsect - no, resspex - reps— restex— *esteem* 'er. After the thing. On Hyder— I mean, Hyrelielelel...the sunny planet."

"Uh-huh."

"And now they're all *fighting*. About why you won't *come."* He huffs, and Huntara raises her eyebrows, still chuckling. He continues, "I've spen' the last…" he flicks up a finger, then another, then another. Then his eyes crease, and he starts again. He gets to a second hand with increasing confusion before he goes with, "*many*. The last *many nights* hearing *just about* how Glimmer's *convinced* i's *her fault* you won't come. And don't get

me *started* on Catra 'n *Adora.*" He knocks back his glass again, then looks at it and says, "Wow, I'm kind of a badass, huh? This goes down like *nothing."*

"...*why?"* Huntara asks.

"Told you; I'm a badass."

"No," Huntara asks, "Why does your girlfriend think I won't come on the mission?"

"Oh," Bow says miserably, "Because she's bad at drinking."

That makes Huntara laugh. And laugh, and laugh.

But she still says no.

A bar in the Crimson Waste

The drink Grenadine plunks down in front of Huntara is bright pink and yellow, with a little cactus flower on an umbrella tucked into it. Huntara curls her lip at it, even though she knows that stepping outside this bar and into the Waste would mean walking into a field of these things, these days - the flowers, not the drink, though the drink is even more out of place to Huntara's sensibilities. The confused-and-horrified look on Grenadine's usually unflappable face as she says, "Uh, from the lady over there," suggests she feels the same way, though maybe that's just her reaction to someone having her make it for *Huntara.* Which takes either some real idiocy or some major guts, and Huntara is both insulted and intrigued right up until she turns around to see who sent it.

Then she's just insulted.

She narrows her eyes.

The newcomer - because she *is* that, a newcomer, whether she acts like it or not - tips herself back in her chair, eyes narrowing back.

Silence takes the bar, tense and anticipatory. Somewhere in the distance, a single Waste-bird *caws.*

"Well, look who it is," Huntara calls across the room, and, "never seen you out here without some kind of posse." After a moment of thought, she picks up the drink, carrying it across the room in a way that dares anyone to comment on it.

No one does, of course. This is the Crimson Waste, and whether it's floral or not, the Crimson Waste is *Huntara's.*

The table she arrives at is in the very corner of the bar, nestled up against a pair of prickly, potted cacti that are the closest thing the Waste used to have to decor. She lets herself loom darkly for a moment, then places the cutesy drink down in front of the table's single occupant and says, loud enough to carry, "Shouldn't be seeing you out here at all."

It's a deceptively mild tone for the underlying threat. But everyone in the bar recognizes it for what it is, even its intended recipient.

Even if she pretends she doesn't.

"Now," Catra of the Horde drawls, unperturbed, "is that any way to talk to an ally?"

It is, Huntara knows, a pointed reminder that this woman is not *of the Horde* any longer, though Huntara doubts Catra knows how Huntara thinks of her. "Your girl's my ally," Huntara says, refusing to sit, even when Catra gestures broadly to the chair across from her. "You're just some upstart."

"An upstart who took the Waste from you," Catra says.

It stings. Still: “An upstart who couldn’t keep it,” Huntara rejoins.

“Neither could you,” Catra says sharply, leaning forward. She realizes her mistake quickly and tries to lean back into nonchalance once more, but it’s not a demeanor easily recaptured.

Huntara, meanwhile, holds onto hers, even if the words rankle worse the more they come. “Seems I can,” she says, nodding slightly to the bar around them, the way its patrons shift like sand dunes to Huntara’s wind.

Catra snaps rapidly, “Just because I left, doesn’t mean you can say you—” she cuts herself off, and Huntara knows the staccato beat of an opponent who knows they’ve said too much. Catra’s tail is twitching in agitation and the rest of her is tense, eartips to toes, and she sounds more annoyed than blase when she transitions to, “Ugh. Are you going to sit, or what?”

Knowing she just won - a skirmish, not a war or even a battle, but a win nonetheless - Huntara acquiesces. The sour look on Catra’s face as she sits makes it clear that they both sense it, the balance of power right now.

Huntara lounges. Catra lounges too. Huntara does it better.

She gazes at Catra with the placid, bored stare she’s perfected over the years. The one that’s worked on every denizen of and visitor to the Waste, from this nameless bar’s regulars to that idiot Tung Lashor to the ragtag princess trio that up and saved the world.

(The regulars whose allegiance this woman once won in an afternoon; that idiot Tung Lashor who this woman dispatched summarily; that princess trio who this woman ambushed and broke apart, right before the world ended and then restarted again, and yet now calls her friends. Huntara doesn’t know much, but she knows when to be wary. She’d say she knows when not to trust, but the truth is she knows never to trust at all.

That's come under question, once or twice these past few years.

It isn't in question now.)

It's another skirmish, of sorts. Huntara's not sure who wins this one - disconcerting in itself - but finally Catra says, "I heard you beat Sparkles."

It takes force of will not to betray her surprise. She was sure this would be about Hydrelium, had been waiting for some kind of taunt or power play. She says, "Who?"

"Sparkles, y'know, Sparkles," once again, Catra's frustration shines through, "lives in a big old castle, wears a lot of pink, likes it when you call her *your majesty*—"

"Ah," Huntara says, cocking her head. And then, because she has a guess how it'll go, "Glitter."

She's right. Catra's eyes narrow, any attempt at *cool* abandoned. She hisses, "*Sparkles."*

"Uh-huh," Huntara says, winning. Then, casting her mind back, "I beat Glitter at drinking."

This time Catra's hiss is wordless, and so immediate that it almost makes Huntara laugh. She surprises Huntara again, though, by saying, "Yeah. And now," she places a shotglass in front of Huntara, slams a bottle of Geraldine's worst on the table between them. Huntara wonders how she'd missed that Catra had those, but then she stops thinking about it when Catra finishes, "you're gonna try and beat *me."*

Huntara cocks her head to the side, thoughtful. Trying to find the game. "What's this, you defending her honor or something?"

"What?!" Catra's hair stands on end, that's how much the question shocks her. Huntara resists the urge to snigger. "Of *course not*. I'm just *better than her.*"

Huntara eyes her curiously. “Hate to speak ill of the glittery,” she doesn’t, “but just about everyone can hold their liquor better than that one. It’s not that exciting.”

“Well then,” Catra says, just as belligerent though maybe a bit nonsensical, “I’m better than *you.”*

That rings truer. Not in that it *is* true - it’s not, no matter what Catra’s short stint as alleged *strongest in the Waste* would imply - but in that it’s what Catra thinks, why she’s here. A pissing contest, this is.

Huntara shouldn’t rise to it. Huntara *wouldn’t* rise to it.

Except.

Except for that nasty, irritating rankle that this girl *was* hailed as *strongest in the Waste*. Except for how she’d taken half Huntara’s gang with her back when she’d left. Except for how the place this girl had taken the Waste folk back to was, out of everywhere in Etheria, the Fright Zone itself. Except for the word *loser* in her supercilious little mouth, except for how Huntara had already endured enough humiliation in front of her. Except for how Catra may no longer call herself of the Horde, but she’s *of the Horde* to Huntara, and an asshole besides, and that simmers like an angry ember in Huntara’s gut.

“Well,” Huntara says, and she’d like it to still be cool but she knows it’s more of a snarl, “pour, why don’t you?”

Catra does.

—

It takes longer than Huntara would like for her to realize she’s being had.

She should have caught it by the drift of Catra's fingers, the motion of her hands, or by the way she gesticulated wildly with her shotglass. Or maybe how Catra never seemed to give anything but trivialities away, even as her words start, too abruptly, to slur. Huntara should, alternatively, have gotten a signal from a friend or a goon or a regular, though she supposes that's at odds with how everyone in the bar is doing their best *not* to ogle the drinking match in the corner. It should have crossed Huntara's mind that if *Huntara* was even starting to feel the liquor in her head, it was completely unreasonable that *Catra* should still be upright, even the dramatically weaving upright she was.

In the end, it's the performance that does it.

"You," she tells Catra, after an embarrassingly lengthy period during which Huntara has mostly grunted and Catra has peppered her increasingly ridiculous trash talk with entirely random questions about, of all things, Huntara's *life*, "are a bad drunk."

"Wh*aAT?"* Catra says, the words unreasonably pitchy as she flails onto the table, "Ho*w dARE YO—"*

"Please. It's embarrassing," Huntara says, and then adds, "and Flower Girl'll kill me if I let you keep torturing that plant."

To her credit, Catra has the good sense to recognize she's been made. "Damn," she says, and her body suddenly goes back to its more controlled sprawl along the chair. She sits up straighter, adding, "Gonna have to work on that."

Huntara raises a brow. "What, you making a practice of this?"

Catra shrugs, "Never know when it'll come up."

"Do yourself a favor," Huntara tells her, "stick to the intimidation. You're better at it."

Catra blinks at her, taken aback. It occurs to Huntara that that was indeed a compliment she'd doled out, albeit a backhanded

one. She staunchly refuses to let her facial expression change when she does.

"Yeah, well…" Catra says, sharp and defensive and confused. "Just, *come on the stupid mission*, okay?!"

Huntara stares at her. It's not that she didn't think that was what this was about, but, "What." Huntara still says.

"The, the stupid—" Catra huffs in frustration. She grinds out between her teeth, "Look, I…I didn't…mean it…when I called you a loser…"

"Yes, you did," Huntara points out.

"No, I didn't," Catra says, with a level of vitriol that doesn't so much give away the lie as waves it around in the air in case Huntara didn't otherwise notice.

"Yes, you did—"

"I did *not*—"

"—though I'm not sure I'd want to win, by your standards," Huntara says, and Catra glares. Huntara adds, "I turned my back on the Horde for a reason."

"So did I!" Catra shouts.

"Did you? I saw you march in here with—"

"Oh, like it's *so much better* to go *hide*—"

"—*soldiers*, sure you got with it eventually, but—"

"—in a *bar* of all places, just because you got your—"

"—what had to happen for you to—"

"—ass a *little kicked* by a, ugh, just - *Adora wants you, okay!?"*

Huntara stops.

She stares.

Catra stares back. Then, she goes bright red.

"…on the mission!" she splutters. "Adora wants you *on the mission.* The Hydrelians after Prime don't even, like, *know* their planet anymore, and she thinks you have all this *experience,* and I *said* that between us we'd be *fine,"* Catra spits the words, "we did the Horde's stupid survival training, we'd be *fine,* and I *told her that,* and she said she was *okay with it*, but…" Catra glares. She shoves her hands into her hair, clawed tips nearly digging in, "… but she's *sad*, okay. She's *sad* about *you,"* and then she hunches in on herself, and adds, "and she thinks it's *my fault."*

Huntara listens to that. And then she says: "Huh."

"*Huh,"* Catra mimics, with a sneer.

Huntara likes Adora well enough, but she means it when she says dryly, "You'll be amazed to hear how little your girlfriend's moods impact my choices."

"That's *not* how you were acting on Hydrelium," Catra grumbles.

Huntara grimaces. She is suddenly, viscerally aware of how very *young* these women are, and she isn't proud of herself at all.

She mulls it over.

"...you want me to come?" Huntara confirms.

Catra glares harder, says through her teeth, "*Yes."*

"Just so Blondie's not sad."

Catra's hiss is more of a snarl this time, and she says with halting menace, "So. *Adora's.* Not sad."

“Huh,” Huntara says again. It finally clicks, then, Catra’s ploy with the drinking contest and how her fake-drunk trash talk really had been incredibly poor, and considering the questions she had asking...“Fluffy, are you trying to make *friends* with me?”

“No!” Catra’s ears go flat to her head, eyes wide. Her hand shoots under the table, and Huntara would bet money it’s to smooth down a tail that’s gone three times its usual size.

“Using...a drinking competition,” Huntara continues, ignoring her protest, “...where you do not drink.”

Catra grumbles something unintelligible, stiffening in her chair. Her eyes are firmly on the table now, and her claws are digging grooves into it, and it’s a long silence while Huntara just watches her. Finally, glaring at the table, Catra says only slightly louder, “Bow says you have to *talk to people in their way*. Whatever the fuck that means.”

“And you decided my way was...booze.”

Catra snaps, “Well I didn’t think a spar would go well.”

“I could beat you in a heartbeat, fluffball,” Huntara says, and means it.

“Could *not,”* Catra says, and clearly means it too. “I took you down once already, and then I *saved your ass*, remember?”

“Surprised me, and then you had She-Ra on your side,” Huntara says, “I’d take you down easy in a fair fight.”

“I’d never fight you fair,” Catra rejoins, fangs bared, and suddenly - with the threat - no longer looking so thoroughly out of her depth.

She’s so *young*, Huntara thinks again. She’s so young, and if she’d been of the Waste - homegrown, or fully defected, without her climb through the Horde for baggage - she’d have earned Huntara’s respect long ago.

Because *of the Horde*, Huntara had thought of her, but Huntara had been wrong. Ruthless and nasty and underhanded, yes, but not in the cold, oppressive way of the Fright Zone. Catra may have found a kind of success there, and yes, that chills Huntara to the bone, but here - here is where she could *fit.* Here in the corner of this bar, in a way Glimmer and Bow and even Adora had never been able to even pretend to. There is this version of Catra who fits, Huntara thinks, in the Waste, or the Waste-that-was, more aptly; the harsh, hot desert that you could fight with or fight in or fight for, but whichever way you cut it, it was a bid for survival all the time. She's so young, and she fits here, or would have when it was at its most unforgiving, as much as Huntara ever has. Maybe even moreso. It should make Huntara mad, or territorial, or even jealous.

It doesn't.

All at once, it just makes her sad.

"Huh," Huntara says once more, sitting back. And then she says, "Well, when do we leave?"

Planet Hydrelium, again

There is a version of this, Huntara thinks, with a fight.

She doesn't think about *what ifs* very often - eventualities and maybes and, sure, fantasies aren't really Huntara's game, never have been. She *does* things; doesn't stand around thinking about them. But there are exceptions, there *have been* exceptions, more and more since she met She-Ra, and this one - yes, she thinks about this.

Because there is a version of this day, in the heat of Hydrelium's many suns and the harsh rub of its sands, with a fight. A sparring

match or single combat, a familiar monster or an unexpected threat, an intentional challenge or happenstance - some kind of rematch, one where Huntara gets another go at the creature that so thoroughly defeated her on this planet before, or at the woman who did so all that time ago in the Waste. Maybe it's a table-turn, where it's Huntara's time to magnanimously rescue a floundering fighter. Not that— not that Huntara *wants* that, except maybe she does. Maybe that's what she came here for, in a way. Huntara rarely gets beaten, or shown up, and she's honest enough to admit she has been, by an enemy and an ally who have the terrible audacity to be the same person. And maybe Huntara has come to a kind of terms with Catra, but somehow that makes it even worse, what Catra had last seen of Huntara on this planet. It's something about pride, and respect, and capability, and it's not that Huntara has to *prove* herself to *anyone*, except for how sometimes she - fine, she'll admit it, if only in her head - she does.

So: yes, there's a version of today with a fight, and Huntara steps off a spaceship for the third time ever positively itching for it.

Here is how things go instead:

"Are we there yet?" Catra whines, trudging along behind her. "Y'know, if I knew there'd be all this *walking*, I would have stayed back with Bow and Sparkles."

Huntara ignores her.

Adora does not. "You sure about that?" she asks, "With Glimmer all on about *training* for the *rematch*— oh, shit, I was not supposed to say in front of…"

She goes silent, and Huntara doesn't have to look to know that they're having a barely-silent, gesticulated argument about what can and cannot be said in front of Huntara, and whether or not Huntara is listening. Which, to be frank, she mostly isn't.

She does notice when Catra swipes one of the canteens Adora's been carrying - which is a lot, since she'd insisted on being *prepared* - for a swig, because she spits it out immediately after, and it gets on Huntara's *face.* Huntara uses one hand to disdainfully wipe it away, glaring while Catra splutters, "*Adora*, why do you have *more booze?"*

"Oh, huh?" Adora says, then takes a sip herself. She makes a pleased face, then looks at it in surprise. "Maybe I mixed mine up with Glimmer's?"

"Actually, I brought that," Huntara grunts, to cut them off. "It's from the reserves."

"Wow," Adora says, "For a planet with a whole lot of problems, they sure know how to party!"

She passes the canteen off to a cheerfully present Sandy, who takes a big gulp - really, the liquor tolerance on these people is wild, especially in all this *heat* - while Catra goes for Adora's water, instead. As Huntara and then the rest of them settle to a stop, Science Man jogs up, panting, to round out their little search party. Huntara would feel sorrier for him if his exhaustion wasn't bolstered by the fact that he hasn't stopped talking since they left the Hydrelian encampment, but as it is he's still ranting about how moonlight shouldn't work without sunlight at all, and did that planet you came from know that?

Huntara ignores him. So does everyone else.

What she doesn't ignore is his device. Because the sandbeast they're tracking leaves a trail that is invisible to anyone who doesn't know the desert and only barely, sometimes visible to someone who does, and Huntara has something of a hunch.

She's been thinking about it, while she walks. The thought of the thing fills her with a sort of ominous dread, as would anything that's broken multiple of her bones, but she can't shake the idea that something's off with the way it had come and go, particularly

the attack. Because the only thing that she can think of that might make a creature do that is disruption or hunger, and it hadn't seemed particularly hungry, except—

"Hey, Science Man," she says, and Science Man stops chattering long enough to glance at her, though he does not remove his hands from his knees. "Stick your, uh...sensey thingy in the ground - not on the dune, next to it." He nods, straightens first his body and then his shirt, then pulls out his device and goes to stab it downwards. Before he can complete the broad gesture, Huntara grabs his hand. "*Gently,*" she growls.

This - it *seems* like any other sand dune, but Huntara has been desert-dwelling for decades. This desert may be brighter, hotter, harsher, and more liquor-obsessed than the Crimson Waste, but it's still a *desert*, and there are some things about the desert that are familiar as the pieces of bone she presses through her ears every morning. And this - this is *not* a normal sand dune.

More meekly, Science Man taps the device into the ground. As a quick test of her theory, Huntara takes her canteen of water out and pours a generous amount onto the sand beside it. Science Man's machine makes the ever so slightest blip as the liquid just sits there on the surface layer, then goes back to silent just as it has every other time they had - as Huntara understands it - tried to water the place.

As she expected. "Hey, Blondie," she says, "pour out that drink. All of it."

"What?" Adora turns to her, canteen of booze halfway to her mouth.

Huntara just raises her eyebrows.

"But—" Adora starts, then sighs. "...if you say so." She pours it out, a stream of liquor dripping into the sand. It settles there, for a moment, shimmering in the sunshine.

Then, it disappears. Sucked like it was taken by some invisible straw into the ground.

The ground, which begins to roil underneath them.

Everyone braces against the quake of it; Science Man falls down on his ass while Catra's claws slide out in the same moment that She-Ra's sword glitters into being from *nowhere*, which - oh. So that's where she keeps that now. *Huh*. Huntara blinks away her surprise to muster a firm voice, ordering, "Stop - don't move!"

Adora freezes. So does Catra, which surprises Huntara, though she endeavors not to show it.

There is a suspended, tense moment that is probably actually quite brief but feels endless, as the ground shifts and then *raises* and the sand sloughs off it in sheets, and then Science Man *shouts* as a piece of thing under them begins *curling above them*, a monumental tentacle emerging from the desert, its tapered tip hanging above them even as they all rest on the broad trunk of it, which runs parallel to the ground. Huntara braces all over again, and she can tell Adora and Catra do too, recognizing the possibility of a fight; the urge not to *start* that fight is real and vivid and so, so tempting.

She doesn't give in, though, which - she's not sure if she's always been able to do that, huh. The tentacle waves in the wind. It curls down, and Huntara holds her breath, murmuring, "Don't…move…" as it slides near first her and then Science Man, then Sandy and then stalls out at Adora.

It pushes forward with intent, then, and Huntara grabs at Catra's wrist just as her claws slide out again, as Catra shouts, "Ado—"

The tentacle knocks…all the canteens. Off Adora's shoulder. To the ground.

The impact is enough to open at least a couple of them, and *glug* of liquid-on-sand is, for a moment, the only sound outside the ambience of the desert. Only some of it sucks into the ground -

the other canteen of booze she'd loaded into Adora's arms, Huntara thinks - and Huntara nods to herself.

She starts, "It's not going to hurt—"

"Ah!" Sandy scrambles away from her spot on the tentacle, scrambling sandily behind Huntara as she breathes - breathes? She's made of *sand,* but *fine* - harshly in Huntara's ear. Huntara blinks in surprise, but then she too recoils as she looks down to find something black and glittering and beseeching sticking out of the sand.

An eye.

It's an *eye.*

"What the *fuck,"* Catra says, as they all look. And then, there's another eye.

And another.

A fourth.

A *fifth.*

They are enormous, set into the dune cautious and plaintive. By now, enough sand has shifted off the twitching tentacle they're standing on; there's no missing as the last of the liquor absorbs into the creature's skin, and its eyes droop almost contentedly.

A moment later, the sand around that piece of the tentacle goes dark with dampness - but not just resting on the surface, this time. The water leeches into the space below the creature, into earth where there isn't even really *earth*, and Science Man's device begins to sing.

He stares. Actually, everyone except Huntara stares.

"What—" Science Man asks.

"The liquor festival," Catra says, clearly making the connection. "*That's* why they used to pour their liquor out."

Huntara nods sharply, vindicated. "Magic or science or both," she says, "I think this thing is what makes this planet tick."

Adora catches on next. Of course she does.

"...so Horde Prime hunted it," She says, her eyes big and blue and horrified and even a little teary. "And it *ran* and *hid* and it wasn't like Krytis because Prime *stayed here* for *ages* and *oh—"* she falls to her knees on the wide plane of the creature's tentacle, "I *stabbed you*, I am *so sorry!"* She presses her hands to its rubbery membrane, right below its eyes. It leans tentatively into the touch, trilling bird-like.

"I don't understand," Sandy says. (Science Man is also wailing about *not understanding* in the background, but that seems to have more to do with the apparently nonsensical science of a giant liquor-eating, special-water-producing desert-creature, so Huntara once again ignores him.) Sandy continues, "I get that it seems this creature - or, well, something like it, I don't know if it's the same one - was part of our ceremonies, but...how? You saw how *terrifying* it was during the festival; how could they possibly have considered it to be benevolent?"

Huntara opens her mouth to answer, but Catra is already shaking her head. "It probably didn't act like that, back then," she says. She's staring at the creature behind her sunglasses, Huntara thinks, but more than that past the creature, into the distance or the past, "Prime...well. You spend enough time with someone like him out to get you, and eventually all you know how to do is fight."

"And hide," Huntara adds, gravely. "You don't get to do much actual living, times like that."

There's a moment there, the pair of them in the desert. It might be a somber one, except that Adora's still cooing and Science

Man's still rambling, so it isn't.

Huntara is fine with that.

"Catra!" Adora announces obliviously, still caressing the creature's face. "Catra, you have to go get the rest of the alcohol."

"*Me?"* Catra shifts, and rejoins with an indignant shout of, "Why *me!?"*

"Because you're fast," Adora says.

"Excuse *you*! Remind me who has super magic strength to carry shit with?"

"I have to stay with her," Adora says, "Huntara can go with you."

"What do you *mean* you have to stay with her," Catra's hands are on her hips and her tail is whipping back and forth. "What if *I* want to stay with the watery...sand...tentacle...thing?" she falters, rallies, "You ever think of *that?"*

"*Catra*," Adora draws out the word, a whine almost on the level of when she's drunk, though she definitely isn't drunk now. She turns around, taking her hands off the creature to instead push herself up and turn to her girlfriend. "I *stabbed* her! I have to *stay!"*

She drapes her arms over Catra's shoulders, using the touch to first - it appears - attempt to draw Catra close. When Catra does not allow her feet to be moved and, in fact, crosses her arms, Adora instead just uses the touch to draw *herself* closer to the stationary *Catra.* She's got her forehead tipped against a presumably-glaring-behind-sunglasses Catra's when she adds, "*Please?*"

She's probably pouting. Huntara's not at the right angle to see Adora's face, but the whole thing is so utterly transparently manipulative that she nearly laughs. Which Catra *has to know*, but Huntara *is* at the right angle to see Catra's body cave even before

her words do, leaning forward into Adora's like an instinct or a habit and her tail curling around Adora's calf. "You *suck*," she says.

"Not because you like me, yeah?" Adora says, and it's soft, private.

"Something like that," Catra murmurs back. Her arms uncross, finally, and she grips the collar of Adora's jacket, an edge in each hand. "You'd be too slow, anyway."

The insult sounds, even to Huntara's unpracticed ears, like something else. Old, new. Comfortable. As settled as Catra was, back when they'd talked in the bar. Maybe even moreso.

"Mhm," Adora says, and kisses Catra very briefly, and then laughs so bright it breaks whatever mood they've built between and around them entirely. She bounces backwards, grinning triumphantly, "So! You should get going, so you can be back soon!" She flashes another grin, and then skips her way back to keep petting the tentacled creature in the sand.

Catra stands there in what appears to be a daze, and Huntara steps up beside her.

Huntara should wonder how this could possibly be the same woman who had the merciless, cruel arrogance to take the Waste in a day. But then, she suspects it isn't. This, she decides, isn't bad.

"Aw, Fluffy," she mocks anyway, in a deadpan coo, "you've gone *soft."*

Catra shakes herself out of whatever reverie she'd been in, then snorts. "Takes one to know one," she replies immediately. She adjusts her sunglasses, then gestures expansively at the creature Huntara didn't let her attack.

Huntara could argue. The habit is there, to argue. But—

—Huntara looks at the desert, and it makes her miss the Crimson Waste. Not just the quicksand and the snakes and the backstabbing, but the flowers, too. The light, harsh enough for a glare but gentler, ultimately, than this planet's. It's not the roughest place out there, fine. But, well. Maybe that isn't bad, either.

"C'mon, fluffball," Huntara says. She slings an arm over Catra's shoulders, then laughs when Catra hisses at her, but doesn't actually move away. "Let's get this squid a drink."

End Notes

Hi. Notes.
-For anyone else who didn't see "Huntara character study ft her relationship to Catra" coming as my next entry here...same
-There's a lot more *there* there to Huntara & Catra that I couldn't even tackle - Catra's relationship to the Horde/Horde Prime/brainwashing and the way both of them approach leadership are two things that ALMOST made it in here but ultimately didn't need to. I may one day come back to this pair or even this fic just for them to spend time on it, but ultimately those items weren't actually necessary for this story, and like. Look. One conversation in a bar can only take so much. But anyway now they're besties and I love them.
-This also didn't fit, but my hc involves Catra drinking somewhere between minimally and not at all, most of the time. Does not like things that fuck with her mental state.
-Thanks to machabubblecat and wildangeline for the sun-themed technobabble
-I want it on record that I wrote like 80% of this fic BEFORE going to see Dune. It has nothing at all to do with Dune. Please do not talk to me about Dune
-The alternate summary for this was "in which I hang a lampshade on the sun"
-This was not supposed to take itself nearly as seriously as it ended up doing. Idk. It was just supposed to be comedy spots of Huntara drinking with the BFS. *idk*
-Adora does not wear sunglasses because even in Adora form she's too magic to need them.
-Sandy's name is actually Sandy. Huntara still does not know this.
-I had other notes but I forgot them so here just take the fic.
-oh i remembered one: yes, it is another tentacle beast who is a bro. One of the joys of writing your own fanfic is that you get to write things that you want.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!